



Halley's Comet opal

△ Full view of the Halley's Comet opal

According to *Guinness World Records*, this impressive rock, which is roughly the size of a man's clenched fist, is the largest uncut black opal in the world. It was found in November 1986 by a group of five Australian miners known as "the Lunatic Hill Syndicate". They named it after the comet that was passing through the southern skies at the time of their discovery, which is only visible from Earth every 75 years.

This nodule, or "nobby", was found at an open-cut mine near the outback town of Lightning Ridge in New South Wales, which boasts the largest deposits of black opal on the planet. The syndicate consisted of two brothers and a small company, which provided financial backing as well as the earth-moving equipment. They operated at the Leaning Tree Claim on Lunatic Hill. The hill's curious nickname dates back to the early days of mining on the site. Most experienced prospectors



Halley's Comet opal at auction, Bonhams, Los Angeles, USA

worked on the shallow flats below it, making their finds just a few feet below the surface. Only a madman would start at the top of the hill, they joked, as he would need to dig a very long way before discovering anything. Nevertheless, a lone miner tried it and his claim proved to be the most successful of all. The syndicate's efforts certainly vindicated their adoption of this painstaking approach, as the

Halley's Comet opal was eventually located at a depth of 20m (66ft) below the surface.

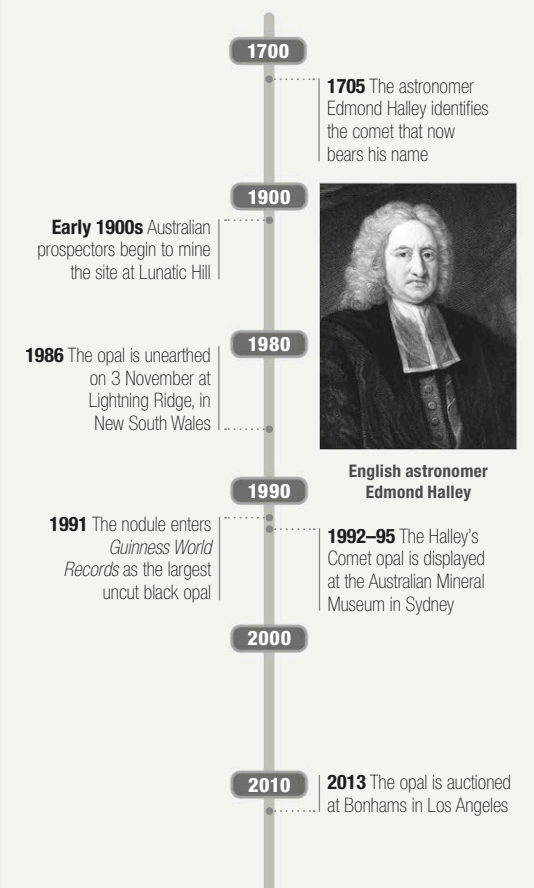
Opals hold a special place in the Australian psyche. It is the country's national gemstone and it features in many legends that predate the arrival of European settlers. Aboriginal mythology relates how, in the Dreamtime, the Creator came down to earth on a rainbow, bearing his message of peace. Then, at the point where his foot touched the ground, the stones turned to opals, sparkling with all the colours of the rainbow.



Opal mine in rural Australia, showing the typical open-cut technique used to mine opals, whereby material is extracted from the surface rather than from deeper ground using tunnels

Key dates

1705–2013



... opal resembles a fraction of the rainbow softened by a milky cloud

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